

Chapter 92-1

Liang Shi understood what Cheng Ran wanted to say, but she couldn't accept it.

Infidelity couldn't become noble just because it was covered with a layer of physiological needs.

On the other end of the phone, Cheng Ran paused, then laughed lightly: "Fine, you've reformed yourself, so I'm the trash."

Liang Shi didn't make a sound.

After a while, Cheng Ran was probably choked by smoke and coughed, then asked hoarsely: "Have you seen Qi Jiao recently?"

"No," Liang Shi said. "Why are you asking about her? Can't you find her?"

"Obviously." Cheng Ran scoffed lightly. "Would I ask you if I could find her?"

Liang Shi: "When asking someone for help, you should have the attitude of someone asking for help."

Cheng Ran: "....."

"Who the fuck is asking for help?" Cheng Ran still had that cocky attitude. "I was just asking casually. If you haven't seen her, then forget it. It's not like she's irreplaceable anyway."

Liang Shi gritted her teeth: "Cheng Ran, what's wrong with you?"

Cheng Ran: "?"

"Liang Shi, what are you pretending for?" Cheng Ran's voice was accompanied by loud wind sounds that made her voice sound fragmented. "Do you think losing your memory can change all the trash things you did before? When you and I hung out together, you weren't this morally upright."

Liang Shi opened her mouth but didn't refute.

Cheng Ran's voice was extremely cold, carrying disdain and contempt: "Once trash, always trash. Don't try to pretend you're some noble good person."

Liang Shi: "....."

A few seconds later, Liang Shi said: "If you have nothing else to say, I'm hanging up."

"Wait." Cheng Ran called out, but didn't speak for a long time.

The wind on her end was very loud, whooshing and blowing into Liang Shi's quiet living room.

Xu Qingzhu sat quietly on the floor with her knees hugged, her hair half-wet and hanging on her shoulders. Liang Shi's hand rested intermittently on Xu Qingzhu's hair tips, her movements gentle.

Just when Liang Shi had lost patience and wanted to hang up, Cheng Ran finally spoke: "If you see her again, pass on a message for me."

"What?"

"Tell her that I once had three-tenths of my heart for her too."

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Three-tenths of a heart on a scale of ten was already the greatest sincerity Cheng Ran could give.

At that moment, Liang Shi had ten thousand things she wanted to say, such as: How much is your sincerity worth? Do you think others should go through fire and water for your three-tenths of sincerity? Do you think that's cool? Do you really think Gu Xingyue should give everything for your three-tenths of a heart and tolerate your debauchery?

.....

There were too many things she wanted to scold her for, but in the end she didn't say a single word and just hung up the phone directly.

Whether it was worth it or not should be left for the person involved to judge.

Just like Bai Weiwei before, she loved Chen Liuying so much that she was willing to give up herself—no one could persuade her otherwise. Instead, anyone who tried to advise her would be placed on the opposite side.

Liang Shi had always maintained a neutral attitude toward such things: respect.

After the phone call ended, the room fell into a strange silence.

The living room light was dim and yellow. Liang Shi placed the white towel back on top of Xu Qingzhu's head. Xu Qingzhu's head tilted back, and her half-wet hair fell on Liang Shi's legs.

The wind suddenly blew open the window. The bad weather in the evening seemed to be preparing for this moment. In an instant, dark clouds gathered, and the wind howled, rolling up dead branches and rotten leaves, blowing down the yellow leaves that stubbornly hung on the treetops in unison, sweeping them all away into the distance together.

Liang Shi got up to close the window, then locked it before returning to the living room.

"How ridiculous," Xu Qingzhu suddenly said coldly.

Liang Shi pressed her lips together, knowing she was talking about Cheng Ran, and said in a low voice: "Yes."

"Why would she think others would treasure her three-tenths of sincerity?" Xu Qingzhu said. "Gu Xingyue loved with ten-tenths, but she only gave three-tenths, and she still acted like she was being charitable from a high position. Why should Gu Xingyue be with her?"

Liang Shi shook her head on her own. "I mentioned to Gu Xingyue before to stay away from Cheng Ran."

"She didn't listen?" Xu Qingzhu asked.

Liang Shi answered in a low voice: "I don't know, but looking at how things are now, she probably didn't listen."

Liang Shi had only mentioned it to Gu Xingyue before. At that time, Gu Xingyue even disliked her, so naturally she wouldn't take her advice to heart.

She was mainly afraid that Gu Xingyue would get hurt.

Looking at it now, this was unavoidable.

After all, for someone like Cheng Ran to be willing to give three-tenths of her heart...

The reason why players are attractive is because they're promiscuous, they treat the whole world with cynicism, but they've given you three-tenths of their heart—ordinary people like this kind of uniqueness.

Especially good girls like Gu Xingyue.

But they forget that if they dated ordinary people, they could get seven or eight-tenths of sincerity, ten-tenths of love.

Why settle for three-tenths?

Xu Qingzhu picked at her nails and suddenly said: "Teacher Liang, blow-dry my hair for me."

"Okay." Liang Shi got up to get the hairdryer from the cabinet in the bathroom.

She still sat on the sofa. The warm wind blew through her fingers, then through Xu Qingzhu's hair strands wrapped around her fingers, and then toward the top of Xu Qingzhu's head.

Xu Qingzhu continued to think while facing the paper.

After Liang Shi finished blow-drying her hair, she took the hair tie from her own arm to tie up Xu Qingzhu's hair. As her fingers ran through her smooth hair, Xu Qingzhu suddenly said: "Go wait at the kindergarten tomorrow and see if you can catch Gu Xingyue. Don't contact her by phone anymore."

"Mm." Liang Shi responded with a sound.

Xu Qingzhu spun the pen in her hand once, then drew a line on the paper. "I'm guessing she was discovered by Yang Jiani about her relationship, then she wanted to resist Yang Jiani to be with Cheng Ran. But when she went to find Cheng Ran again, she discovered Cheng Ran was already mixing around with someone else. Her heart died. She might have wanted to give up on herself, or she realized that after Yang Jiani discovered her behavior, it would cause serious consequences, so she called you. But she didn't expect Yang Jiani to discover that too, so her situation is very dangerous right now."

Liang Shi: "....."

After listening to Xu Qingzhu's entire chain of speculation, Liang Shi felt like she hadn't brought her brain and could only ask: "Why? How did you analyze all that?"

"When we were on the phone just now, Cheng Ran said she and Gu Xingyue had broken up once before," Xu Qingzhu said. "So why would Gu Xingyue break up with her before? Even Cheng Ran could say something like 'three-tenths of a heart,' which means they should have been in the honeymoon phase before, but Gu Xingyue initiated the breakup. Before discovering Cheng Ran's infidelity, apart from being threatened after Yang Jiani found out, I can't think of any other reason."

"But why would Yang Jiani be against her dating?" Liang Shi asked subconsciously.

After asking, she fell silent.

She suddenly thought of it.

Xu Qingzhu also fell silent accordingly. The pen tip scribbled randomly on the paper. A few seconds later, she scoffed lightly: "How could Yang Jiani let her date? She's Qi Jiao now. If she dates, where would Yang Jiani find a puppet for emotional sustenance?"

Liang Shi lowered her brows and eyes and sighed heavily. "Gu Xingyue....."

After saying just her name, she couldn't describe it further.

Too tragic.

A tragedy that words couldn't describe.

"Weak people can only seek self-protection," Xu Qingzhu said coldly. "Only by being strong enough can one avoid being so tragic."

After she finished speaking, she put the paper and pen on the table and stood up, saying: "Alright, Teacher Liang, let's go to sleep."

After she suddenly stood up, she was a bit taller than Liang Shi. Liang Shi looked up at her, and the backlight happened to illuminate her entire person, making her look gentle and beautiful.

Even though she had no smile on her face.

"Xu Qingzhu." Liang Shi suddenly called her name warmly.

Xu Qingzhu's tone rose at the end: "Mm?"

Liang Shi's light brown pupils focused on her. "Good night."

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That "good night" was said so tenderly that even after Xu Qingzhu returned to her room, the sound still echoed in her ears.

Meanwhile, Liang Shi still sat in the living room, holding the paper with Xu Qingzhu's analysis. Her fingertips rubbed across the paper surface as she lowered her brows and eyes in contemplation.

She speculated that if Gu Xingyue was being confined, she should be locked in that basement from when they were children.

Dark and sunless, with some implements for hitting people hanging on the walls.

But Liang Shi didn't remember the location of the basement. She only knew it was a basement.

Tomorrow she could only go to the kindergarten under the pretext of visiting the children.

While Liang Shi was lost in thought, her phone vibrated slightly. She picked it up and discovered it was a message from Gu Yixue.

Gu Yixue had sent a ten-second voice message.

After seeing it, Liang Shi felt a bit nervous, as if she was going to an interview. She held the phone to her ear before pressing play.

As a result, the volume was too high, startling her with a shudder.

She didn't hear what Gu Yixue said at all. Instead, she hurriedly lowered the volume.

Just as she finished adjusting it and was about to play it again, the master bedroom door suddenly opened. Xu Qingzhu stood in the doorway, her voice lazy: "Teacher Liang, do we have guests at home?"

Liang Shi: "?"

She was confused. "No."

Xu Qingzhu leaned against the doorframe. "Then why is there a woman's voice?"

Liang Shi: "....."

Xu Qingzhu said: "It sounds quite nice."

Liang Shi: "....."

After going around three bends, she finally understood what Xu Qingzhu meant. She held up her phone to show her the screen. "It's the director I added yesterday contacting me. It should be about the production. Do you want to listen together?"

Xu Qingzhu shook her head: "It's your work, you handle it."

Liang Shi detected danger from her indifferent voice. In her mind suddenly floated the memory of last night when Xu Qingzhu asked her in an especially alluring voice, "Am I prettier or... is Quella prettier?"

Xu Qingzhu sounded very nice when she spoke English, with a hint of coquettishness.

The fragrance from her hair tips made Liang Shi lose focus.

And at this moment, Liang Shi suddenly said: "Does her voice sound nice?"

Xu Qingzhu nodded: "It sounds nice. I like it."

Liang Shi: "....."

"I don't like it." Liang Shi said seriously. "I think Teacher Xu's voice sounds better than this."

Xu Qingzhu: "....."

After the initial shock, Xu Qingzhu leaned her head against the door and smiled with curved lips. Those beautiful eyes looked upward, and her curved eyes were full of scattered light. "Teacher Liang, when did you learn to sweet-talk?"

Liang Shi seriously defended herself: "These are all sincere words."

Xu Qingzhu looked at her frivolously, her face saying five words—Do you think I believe you?

Regardless of whether Xu Qingzhu believed it or not, Liang Shi had in any case recovered her long-lost survival instinct.

She wanted to hear the voice message Gu Yixue sent. Her heart itched with wanting to know what Gu Yixue said, whether she was directly handing her an excellent script. When searching online, it said that Gu Yixue was about to film "Heart's Path," which was about the love of idealists.

Currently in the preparation stage.

Liang Shi had her eye on this. Even if they didn't pay her, she'd be fine playing a small role.

After all, being able to guest star in a famous director's production would directly raise her status after filming.

Moreover, a good script was hard to come by.

But with Xu Qingzhu standing there, Liang Shi wanted her to hear it but also didn't want her to hear it.

After all, Gu Yixue's voice was quite... sexy.

And Xu Qingzhu had even said she liked her voice.

After hesitating for a moment, Liang Shi called Xu Qingzhu over.

Xu Qingzhu crossed her arms and leaned against the door, asking airily: "What for?"

Liang Shi said: "Sit with me for a while."

Then she converted Gu Yixue's voice message to text. Just then, Xu Qingzhu sat on the sofa as if she had no bones, looking somewhat sleepy. Her eyes were half-closed, and the hair that had just been tied up was already messy. A few strands stood up in the air due to static electricity, messy yet orderly.

Liang Shi handed over her phone. The machine-translated text read: [Hello? I'm awake now. Are you asleep? Let's chat about something.]

A very simple and straightforward sentence.

Without her previous words as context, what they'd be chatting about in the middle of the night was unclear.

The light fell on Xu Qingzhu's eyelashes, casting a shadow over her eyelids. Xu Qingzhu said in a drowsy voice: "Just play her voice message. I want to hear it."

Liang Shi: "?"

"Not playing it." Even Liang Shi's speech had a pinched quality to it. "What's so good about listening to it? You should go back to sleep."

Xu Qingzhu: ".....So petty."

Liang Shi tapped on the screen and sent a message: [What is it?]

Xu Qingzhu asked her: "Can I look?"

Liang Shi put the phone in the middle without any evasiveness. Xu Qingzhu's head naturally rested on her shoulder, barely touching it with no real weight.

After hesitating, Liang Shi moved closer to Xu Qingzhu's side, allowing her to rest more comfortably against her.

The two of them leaned against the sofa together.

Xu Qingzhu's voice carried drowsiness, and when lowered, it seemed like acting spoiled: "Just play it once."

Just then, Gu Yixue sent a second voice message, 20 seconds long.

Liang Shi: "....."

She converted it to text again and firmly answered: "Not playing it."

But this time Gu Yixue's voice message was a mix of Chinese and English. The text conversion couldn't accurately express her meaning. Xu Qingzhu watched with a smile from the side, then reached out her hand and directly pressed play, smoothly pressing Liang Shi's hand to turn up the phone volume a bit.

Gu Yixue said on the other end: "Do you have availability recently? Are you filming 'Afterglow'? I have a role here that's suitable for you....."

What followed was all in English, talking to someone else, speaking rather impatiently. The general meaning was: "You're bothering me with such a trivial matter? I'm not changing this script. She can come if she wants, or forget it if she doesn't."

As soon as the voice message finished playing, Gu Yixue's side clicked to recall it.

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Xu Qingzhu listened from the side with a smile and sincerely praised: "Her voice is so magnetic. This director is called Quella? Can I follow her? Does she have any works?"

Liang Shi: "....."

Liang Shi gave up completely and played the previous voice message for her to hear as well.

When Gu Yixue said "Hello," her tone rose at the end, carrying a hint of flirtation that seemed to be there yet not, though it wasn't intentional.

After listening, Xu Qingzhu let out a light breath and gently bumped Liang Shi's arm. "If you're filming then, can I visit the set?"

Liang Shi: "....."

She asked in a muffled voice: "Are you going to see me or to see Quella?"

"To see you, of course." Xu Qingzhu answered without thinking. "And I can see Quella along the way."

Liang Shi's mood improved briefly for one second, but then Xu Qingzhu's next sentence said: "I don't know her either, so you'll have to introduce me."

Liang Shi: "....."

She tapped on the topmost voice message again—it was the one Gu Yixue had sent her last night after drinking too much. Her voice carried the hoarseness after getting drunk, along with a hint of drowsiness.

It was indeed very ear-catching.

After Xu Qingzhu finished listening, her eyes brightened, and when her arm bumped Liang Shi, she used more force. It hurt so much that Liang Shi sucked in a breath of cold air, then bit her lip and called out with a slightly threatening tone: "Teacher Xu~"

Xu Qingzhu's voice was lazy. "Mm? Play it again."

Liang Shi: "....."

She directly turned off the screen, her finger drawing a circle on it as she asked unwillingly in a lowered voice: "Does it sound that good?"

Xu Qingzhu nodded: "Don't you think her voice after getting drunk... is very sexy?"

The two were already sitting very close, and as they talked they unconsciously moved even closer, so close that Liang Shi's breath was entirely exhaled into Xu Qingzhu's hair tips. The hot air passed through her hair tips and fell on her skin.

Xu Qingzhu felt a bit ticklish and shrank her neck, but also asked back unwilling to be outdone.

Liang Shi denied it against her conscience: "I don't think so."

"But I think so." Xu Qingzhu nudged her. "Teacher Liang, play it again."

Liang Shi took the remote and turned on the TV. "Let's watch a movie."

Xu Qingzhu said, "I need to sleep."

"You were just listening to her talk and didn't say you needed to sleep." Liang Shi said: "How come watching a movie means you need to sleep? I'll show you her movie."

Xu Qingzhu: ".....Then okay."

Liang Shi was annoyed and lightly pinched her waist.

Xu Qingzhu grabbed her hand. "What? Are you bullying me?"

"No." Liang Shi said: "Your waist is too slim."

"Then won't you hold me?"

Xu Qingzhu moved closer to her. The atmosphere was just right. Her voice was low, husky, and alluring. Liang Shi's heart stirred, and her long arms reached over to embrace her waist. Her hand happened to rest on her lower abdomen, and the two instantly drew close.

It was like holding an ice block.

Liang Shi said in a low voice: "Why are you so cold?"

Xu Qingzhu didn't mind. "It's a constitution issue."

Liang Shi held her tighter. The movie playing was "The Messenger."

Not long after the opening credits started, the words "Director: Quella" appeared. Moreover, before the movie was about to begin, there was a subtitle in the lower right corner that read: All the lettering used in the opening credits of this film was handwritten by Director Quella. Thank you to all the participating guests and staff.

Xu Qingzhu naturally exclaimed: "This person's handwriting is also beautiful."

Liang Shi made a sound of acknowledgment. "It's alright, I guess."

Xu Qingzhu watched with the pure purpose of appreciation. Liang Shi received another voice message from Gu Yixue. This time she asked: "Are you busy? Can we have a phone call?"

From the several messages she had sent, one could judge that this was a resolute and decisive person.

Her personality was straightforward and cheerful, yet carried a mysterious air, perhaps related to her charming appearance.

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Liang Shi showed Xu Qingzhu her phone. Xu Qingzhu paused the TV and gestured for her to answer.

Liang Shi first sent her a message: [Okay.]

Just as she was about to tap the voice call, Gu Yixue's side called over. Liang Shi answered in a panic, and only after connecting did she realize it was a video call.

Gu Yixue was still wearing a black camisole top, revealing her lean arms without any excess fat and her beautiful collarbones. She wasn't the type who was so pale she glowed—she had normal yellow-toned skin—but her facial features and figure gave people a strong visual impact, with a naturally innocent yet sexy and charming aura.

In the video, her hair was casually clipped up with hairpins. In front of her was a glass of blue cocktail. Her home had a natural wood-colored décor style, and the lighting was all warm-toned, which didn't match her temperament at all.

After seeing this, Liang Shi subconsciously looked at Xu Qingzhu and discovered she had already sat up, looking quite proper.

"....."

Gu Yixue also hadn't expected there to be someone else beside Liang Shi, but it didn't matter. She cut straight to the point: "You looked up information about me, right?"

Liang Shi nodded: "Quella?"

"Mm-hmm." Gu Yixue said: "You can just call me that when filming. I'm going to film 'Heart's Path' next. The script is written, but it still needs adjustments. Do you want to act in it?"

Liang Shi nodded. "Of course."

Gu Yixue asked her: "What do you want to play?"

"I'll play whatever's available." Liang Shi said: "I'm not picky."

Gu Yixue: "Hm? You're not even going to ask? What if it's just a small supporting role?"

"Being able to play a small supporting role in your movie shouldn't be bad either, right?" Liang Shi smiled lightly. "Director Quella."

Gu Yixue raised her wine glass and swirled it. "Looks like you researched quite thoroughly."

Talented people generally have pride, but this pride isn't unlikeable.

Moreover, for someone like Gu Yixue, it could no longer be called pride—it was simply confidence in one's own capabilities.

Liang Shi said to her: "You can arrange it as you see fit. Capable directors can often arrange actors in suitable positions."

Just like Gu Yixue when filming now—she didn't need to worry about money at all. There were plenty of people who wanted to invest.

Moreover, she had absolute say. Even if investors put up hundreds of millions, if she didn't want them to insert people, she wouldn't accept it. If investors wanted to make money, they had to listen to her. Otherwise, Gu Yixue would directly give up, and no one would benefit.

After hearing her words, Gu Yixue smiled. "You'll play the female lead."

Liang Shi: "!"

"The person next to you..." Gu Yixue only said one sentence before changing the subject. "Your girlfriend?"

"My wife." Liang Shi said: "I'm married."

Before, she had said it with a guilty conscience and no confidence. As she said it more and more times, Liang Shi could already introduce it very naturally.

After all, she wasn't lying, was she?

"She's quite pretty." Gu Yixue asked: "Is she also an actress?"

"No." Xu Qingzhu answered herself: "I can't act."

"Being pretty, just standing there is already a performance." Gu Yixue smiled. "If you want to act, you can come find me. I like pretty people."

Xu Qingzhu was infected by her smile and agreed: "Alright, then let me say thank you in advance."

Liang Shi: "....."

"By the way." Gu Yixue said to Liang Shi: "You film 'Afterglow' first. After you finish filming, we'll talk in detail. I need to rest."

Liang Shi: ".....Okay."

"'Heart's Path' has dual female leads." Gu Yixue's gaze steadied, and she smiled with curved lips, carrying a bit of roguishness that wasn't unlikeable. "I plan to use all newcomers, so your partner will be like you."

"Okay, I'm fine with anything." Liang Shi said.

"The emotions in 'Heart's Path' are very complex, so... you'd better get to know your partner first. Once I start filming, I want results. I don't want to NG over twenty times." Gu Yixue said: "During this time, you should get to know each other. I don't want wooden emotions."

When talking about this, Gu Yixue naturally carried a serious air. Liang Shi said: "That's fine."

"I'll push her WeChat to you." Gu Yixue said: "Her name is Sun Chengcheng. She graduated from a media and performing arts program. The biggest role she's played was an extra in her graduation production."

"What's her name?" Liang Shi was shocked.

Gu Yixue repeated: "Sun Chengcheng. Do you have a problem with that?"

Liang Shi: "....."

It took a great effort to calm her emotions. Liang Shi said: "No, just push her WeChat to me."

Gu Yixue casually acknowledged. Just as she was about to hang up, Liang Shi asked: "Can I ask why you want to use me to act?"

Gu Yixue on the screen paused, then smiled lightly, her tone casual. "I really like you—"

She drew out her tone, carrying an alluring and lingering quality. Combined with that face of hers, it was especially heart-stirring.

A heart-stirring purely from appreciating beauty.

Liang Shi's brows furrowed slightly. Gu Yixue watched as the expressions of the two people opposite her changed simultaneously. Like she had appreciated something interesting, she smiled brilliantly like the blazing sun.

Her lazy voice sounded again, casual and carefree: "—eyes."

After hanging up the phone, Liang Shi finally breathed a sigh of relief. But as she looked at her own eyes in the darkened screen, she felt there was nothing special about them.

Xu Qingzhu said in a low voice: "This person is very interesting."

Liang Shi: "....."

"Didn't you say before that it was impossible for you to enter the entertainment industry?"

Liang Shi asked her. "How come when she asks, you're okay with it?"

Xu Qingzhu raised an eyebrow: "I said working with her would be okay."

Liang Shi: ".....Is there a difference?"

"There is." Xu Qingzhu said: "I also want to work with pretty people."

Liang Shi: "....."

She turned her face with a ghostly expression and suddenly made eye contact with Xu Qingzhu.

Xu Qingzhu looked at her light brown pupils and licked her lips, which appeared rippling under the lamplight.

Liang Shi's arm wrapped around her waist, her hand falling on her back. She leaned over and bit directly on the side of her neck. Her teeth rubbed against her skin, then she sucked and kissed.

Imitating how she had been last night, biting her as punishment.

Xu Qingzhu extended her arms and hugged her.

After finishing biting, Liang Shi asked in a breathless voice: "Just how pretty is she?"

Xu Qingzhu was like she had no bones, her body soft, yet she smiled. "Close your eyes and I'll tell you."

Liang Shi: "....."

She obediently closed her eyes.

A moment later, warm lips with moisture fell on her eyelashes. Liang Shi's eyelids jumped along with her heartbeat.

Xu Qingzhu's low, husky voice carried laughter, like a feather sweeping across Liang Shi's heart. In the darkness, all sensations and sounds became unusually clear.

Liang Shi urgently wanted to grasp onto something, so she reached out and pinched her waist.

Xu Qingzhu made a low humming sound. Then that low, husky voice sounded by her ear, lightly alluring: "Not as pretty as Teacher Liang's eyes."
